

AHMEDABAD

Double Trouble

Ayurvedic practitioner Ashok Jadeja's life is the stuff Bollywood dramas like *Mr Natwarlal* are made of. Arrested last week by the Gujarat Police, Jadeja posed as someone who had received the divine blessings of a local deity, Sikkotar Mata, at a temple near his small clinic in Ahmedabad. Thus blessed, he claimed that he had divine powers which could enable him double any amount of money kept in his care. This unique banking solution enticed many who turned to Jadeja to take up such a divine return. He would ask his devotees to deposit their sums and return after a few days to take back their multiplied fortunes. When they turned up, Jadeja had predictably vanished. The

Gujarat Police, which arrested Jadeja and his wife last week with Rs 1.98 crore, say Jadeja's con trick could have collected him as much as Rs 100 crore.

by Uday Mahurkar



JADEJA (SECOND FROM RIGHT) WITH HIS STASH OF CASH

Home Truth

An intruder, posing as "personal staff", managed to get past North Block's 'foolproof security' when Home Minister P. Chidambaram escorted his junior M. Ramachandran on his first day in office. Hopefully, this is not the shape of things to come.

DELHI

Terror Track

Just when the National Investigation Agency (NIA) was beginning to be thought of as a non-starter, Home Minister P. Chidambaram has come to its rescue. The NIA has been given two cases of terrorist acts in Assam involving the Dima Halim Daogah (DHD), to investigate. Headed by Jewel Gario, the DHD has unleashed terror in areas of Cachar, North Cachar Hills, Karbi Anglong and Nagaon districts of Assam. In recent months the Centre has received reports about increasing violence, intimidation, extortion, arms and explosives smuggling by the



CHIDAMBARAM

YASBANT NEGI

group. It has decided to hand over the investigation of two most recent cases to NIA to prove its mettle. "The cases are fit for the NIA since the investigation involves getting to know the source of funding and terror links abroad," says a home ministry official.

by Bhavna Vij-Agron

LUCKNOW High on Inaction

It seems the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is helpless while pursuing cases against those near and dear to Mayawati. Directed by the high court, the CBI had sniffed out an appointment scam in the Information and Publicity Department of the state. It then found former director (information) Mahesh Gupta, senior IAS officer Prabhat Kumar Sinha, additional director Ram Gopal Verma and alleged broker Akhilesh Chand Shukla guilty in different cases. In 2006, the CBI submitted a charge-sheet against all four to a CBI special court in Lucknow. Now Chief Minister Mayawati has appointed Mahesh Gupta as secretary (home), and despite the CBI's efforts (they even sought permission to prosecute Sinha and others) the Government has remained silent on the issue. One of the reminders from CBI headquarters reads, "It's been more than three years and numerous reminders have been sent... The matter is urgent." Of course, their plea has fallen on deaf ears.

by Subhash Mishra



SUBIR HALDER